

DEBATE AS DISEASE: DEBATE AND THE DIALOGUE AND DELIBERATION MOVEMENT

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Even in a democratic state, after all, leaders can become too fond of leading, bureaucracies can become calcified, voters can feel ignored, and pressing issues can go unaddressed. An elected body of representatives, meeting regularly and debating vigorously, has seemed the cure to such problems.

Roderick P. Hart and Courtney L. Dillard

Judgments and criticisms, spoken as well as unspoken, infect our interactions. It's a self-reinforcing, spiraling process that takes on a life of its own leaving often unintended consequences in its wake. Chronic debate is destructive, and despite our best intentions, it takes us down a path that leads in the opposite direction from where we say we want to go.

Deborah L. Flick

Despite its infirmities, deliberation sings a siren song.

Roderick P. Hart and Courtney L. Dillard

Assumptions about the necessary relationship between debate, deliberation and democracy are not only foundational to western thought, they are also found in the disciplinary bedrock of communication studies. Keith (2007) credits early disciplinary scholarship, which he characterizes as “debates about debating,” with rearticulating “the tradition of rhetoric-as-argumentation” and thus, transferring speech instruction from the hands of the elocutionists to the hands of civic minded debate instructors (p. 59). Since then the discipline of communication studies has had a love-hate

relationship with debate, especially contest debating. The perceived value of debate, its utility as a deliberative process, its contributions to democracy and its place within the discipline, has ebbed and flowed (Keith, 2007).

In recent years, the topics of debate, deliberation and democracy, often discussed in terms of “deliberative democracy,” “civil society,” and “public sphere(s),” have once again taken center stage within the communication studies discipline and across the academy. Scholarly interest in the topic of deliberative democracy coincides with a virtual explosion of public discourse on the topic. Scholars and activists alike are busy exploring new forms of “democratic organizing” (Leighninger 2006), and generating interest by governing bodies in “public consultation” (Fishkin 2009). Often discussed in terms of “community building,” “civic and public engagement,” “open government” and “meaningful dialogue,” this discourse tends to circulate in conjunction with newly formed foundations, institutes, and centers all dedicated in some way or another to promoting, encouraging and facilitating more and better democratic participation. To a large extent all this interest is motivated by concerns about the health of democracy and the body politic. Accordingly, concerned public intellectuals note that the signs of illness are clear. On the one hand there is malaise, alienation and cynicism. On the other hand we find dogmatism, intolerance and solipsism.

In addition, there is a rather large and growing network of “process activists and advocates” and professional facilitators who are building coalitions, hosting events, and peddling their wares. Democracy, dialogue, and deliberation are hot topics. In fact, there are so many people in so many different places thinking, writing, and talking about democracy, and so many more inventing, organizing, and engaging in a plethora of democratic experiments, deliberative forums, and dialogue processes that it seems reasonable to say that whether one defines a social movement in terms of phenomena and social organization (Simons 2001;

Simons 1970) or in terms of meaning and ideas (McGee 1980) the people and organizations associated with the dialogue and deliberation community as well as the intellectual currents that inform their actions constitute a vibrant social movement.

Scholarship and activism related to debate have followed suit. The growth of urban debate leagues, the activist turn in inter-collegiate debate (Mitchell 1998; Warner and Bruschke 2001) and a renewed interest in public debate forums and formats (Broda-Bahn, Kempf and Driscoll 2004; Mitchell 2010) testify to a renaissance in the debate community. Yet the Dialogue and Deliberation movement seems to be leaving debate behind, or worse, casting it in the role of villain. In fact, a disconcerting aspect of the Dialogue and Deliberation movement is that debate, as an idea and a practice, is often characterized as largely responsible for the ills associated with contemporary democratic life.

If all philosophy, as the saying goes, is a series of footnotes to Plato, then it might be fair to say that all contemporary Dialogue and Deliberation discourse is a series of footnotes to John Dewey. Dewey believed that democracy is fundamentally a process of communication and that social reform aimed at altering communication processes will revitalize the body politic. Furthermore, he argued that debate is fundamentally a top-down, authority driven, undemocratic form of communication, through which the few manipulate the many (Keith 2007, p. 103; Ehninger 1958, p. 22-23). Given that so many within the dialogue and deliberation movement take their cue, whether consciously or not, from Dewey, it is not surprising that they tend to characterize debate as a disease, which infects democracy.

This paper reexamines this diagnosis, and argues that discourses, which frame debate in terms of disease are counterproductive to the democratic practices they seek to facilitate. More importantly, it argues that the intercollegiate debate community should begin an urgent project of reclaiming debate. In this regard it does not offer a new critique of tournament practices and contest

debating. Instead it calls upon us to renew our scholarly tradition by theorizing about debate and promoting its virtues as a tool for public engagement. It does so by first examining the way that debate is tropically framed as a “disease” in the discourses of the D & D community. In the second section it discusses some of the rhetorical functions associated with the “debate as disease” trope. The third section focuses upon some of the ways that we, in the debate community, might respond to and engage with the D & D community, and in doing so, facilitate better public understanding of debate, and help raise the profile of debate as a topic of scholarly inquiry.

Debate as disease: The idea of debate in the D & D community

From the classical rhetoricians of Greece and Rome to contemporary cognitive linguists such as George Lakoff both the affect and the affective powers of tropes have received considerable attention. In its strictest classical sense “a trope was usually thought of as substitution of one word or phrase for another or a change in the placement of a word or phrase (Kennedy 2001, p. 113). In more contemporary usage a trope also denotes “a significant or recurrent theme” in a body of work or a discourse (Oxford English Dictionary Online 2009). In either case students of rhetoric have long noted and discussed the epistemic and affect(ive) qualities of tropes. As Lakoff and Johnson (1980) argue, “our concepts structure what we perceive, how we get around in the world, and how we relate to other people,” and “our conceptual system is largely metaphorical” (p. 3). Similarly, White (1978) claims “tropics is the process by which all discourse constitutes the objects which it pretends only to describe” (p. 2). Tropes, especially when they become discursive themes, tend to shape the way we experience and interact with the world.

The trope of disease in the discourses of the dialogue and deliberation movement shapes the way that many within that community understand and experience debate. The debate as disease trope generally takes two

forms within these discourses. In the first form, debate is unambiguously represented as a disease through the use of metaphor and analogy. In this form, debate (and argument) is said to “infect our interactions”; to be something that we “lapse into”; and to be a “chronic” and destructive condition (Flick 1998, p. 132). Debate, in the second form of the trope, is not directly labeled in terms of disease, rather it is said to produce a kind of communication dis-ease. In this variation, debate is said to produce dysfunctional communication habits that are cultivated and reinforced in “the argument culture” (Tannen 1998) or “the debate culture” (Flick 1998). These poor communication habits include hyper-competition, either/or thinking, and intolerance, which in turn fuel an “increasingly warlike atmosphere” resulting in dysfunctional interpersonal relationships, a democracy tainted by solipsism and cynicism, and ultimately damage to “the human spirit” (Tannen 1998, p. 280).

In this section I focus largely on the scholarship of Flick (1998) and Tannen (1998) because their texts are early examples of the debate as disease trope. More importantly, their texts are not only representative examples of the way that debate is characterized and framed in the discourse of the D & D community, but both Flick and Tannen offer some of the most thoughtful and reasoned critique of debate. Later in this section I give examples of the way that the “debate as disease” trope is circulating and becoming institutionalized in different organizational settings.

Debate as disease: Flick’s (1998) book *From Debate to dialogue: Using the understanding process to transform our conversations*, provides an excellent example of the unambiguous representation of debate as disease. Flick’s tropic framing of debate begins with the title of her first chapter, “In search of an antidote to the debate culture” (p. 1). This chapter, which also serves as the introduction to her book, posits debate and “debate culture,” as a disease or poison, and suggests that

dialogue, or what Flick calls “the understanding process,” is the antidote for what ails us. Flick’s diagnosis begins with a critique of what she calls, “conversational discussion.” Tracing the Latin root of the word “discuss” (“to dash to pieces; to scatter apart; to quash or crush”), Flick suggests that conversational discussion is akin to, or even synonymous with “dispute, debate, heated argument, and wrangle” (p. 2). She then further explains, “An additional purpose of this book is to name and illuminate the Debate Culture” (p. 2-3).

From Flick’s (1998) perspective debate culture is a kind of silent and invisible killer, and until we are able to make the “invisible visible” by naming that which “infect[s] our interactions,” she contends, we will be unable to devise a cure (p. 132). Debate culture is, according to Flick, the “air we breathe” (p. 3). From her perspective, we are so “steeped” in the culture of debate that we are often unaware of the ways in which it “infects” our interactions. Here Flick draws an analogy between carbon monoxide poisoning and debate. Carbon monoxide is, she notes, “an odorless, tasteless, invisible gas that is deadly when ingested. Without knowing of its existence, it would seem that living beings die for no apparent reason. By naming it, identifying its chemical composition, discovering where carbon monoxide comes from, we know how to avoid its lethal potential” (p. 3). By analogy, she argues, “naming the Debate Culture brings it into fuller view” and “helps us better see the particular ways in which the Debate Culture pervades and is continuously supported and reinforced in our institutions and customary ways of engaging with each other” (p. 3).

The harmful effects of the poisonous debate culture, which result from “our habitual tendency to lapse into debate and argument” are seen in the way debate culture produces “a self-reinforcing, spiraling process that takes on a life of its own,” “generates fear and defensiveness,” and “fosters objectification through stereotyping and negative labeling” (Flick 1998, p. 132). This vicious cycle of rhetorical violence is induced by the

attack-and-defend mentality generated by debate culture: “the very act of defending, often best accomplished by subtlety or overtly attacking, further sharpens the demarcations which require ever stronger modes of defense” (Flick 1998, p. 132).

Like most health education campaigns, the cure to the debate disease begins with awareness: “Awareness can create the impetus to discover and explore different options, like the Understanding Process. Identifying the assumptions and beliefs inherent in the Debate Culture helps us to seek new ways of thinking and interacting” (Flick 1998, p. 3). Most D & D critics agree, explicitly or implicitly, with Tannen’s (1998) assessment that the assumptions and beliefs inherent to debate culture can be found in the “calcified” metaphors that shape our understanding of debate (Tannen 1998, p. 13). Tannen claims that we exist in “a pervasive warlike atmosphere that makes us approach public dialogue, and just about anything we need to accomplish, as if it were a fight,” (p. 3), and that the metaphors associated with debate and argument such as “war,” “battle,” and “fight,” are the root cause of “the argument culture” that produces communication dis-ease. Thus, Flick and Tannen, as well as many others in the D & D community, argue for a movement away from debate to alternative modes of democratic communication such as facilitated dialogue and deliberation.

Debate as dis-ease: The idea that debate and debate culture are responsible for infecting us with communication dis-ease where issues of public and private disagreement are concerned is illustrated in the Program Information guide provided to participants in the Virginia Natural Resources Leadership Institute (VRNLI). The VRNLI offers a nine month course that is designed to create community leaders and a “leadership network of Virginia’s natural resource managers encompassing all sectors (public, private, community, nonprofit)” (VNRLI 2007, p. 2). The worthy goal of the institute is to “provide these leaders with the leadership

skills needed to build consensus around environmental issues, to move beyond conflict to find creative solutions” and to “improve the capacity of Virginia’s communities to engage in productive dialogue and resolution of natural resource issues” (VNRLI 2007, p. 2).

A key aspect of the VNRLI program is training in, and experience with, “a process of structured dialogue” (p. 15). The VNRLI training material begins its lesson on structured dialogue by contrasting debate and dialogue in the following way: “We all know the characteristics of an all out, knockdown, drag-out debate. Opponents line up against one another to seek (or invent) the weakness in others’ statements. Nobody ever admits wrong or uncertainty. The argument begins with the answers and participants defend their answers against all attack” (VNRLI 2007, p. 15). The VNRLI program guide goes on to describe the communication practices associated with debate: “Tactics may include verbal and physical intimidation, name-calling, labeling, and stereotyping. Deception and deliberate distortion of the opponents’ words are also often accepted as part of the game” (VNRLI 2007, p. 15). Next the VNRLI lesson plan offers a more desirable alternative to debate by asking its trainees to “think of the qualities you appreciate in a good dialogue” and offers some examples, such as: “An assumption that you are speaking honestly, without a hidden agenda” (VNRLI 2007, p. 15). Finally, the VNRLI training material summarizes the lesson to be learned by contrasting dialogue and debate as follows: “The question then becomes how to create forums that nourish this type of productive dialogue rather than unproductive debate” (VNRLI 2007, p. 15).¹

The contrast between debate and dialogue offered by VNRLI is, to put it bluntly, unrecognizable to

¹ Portions of this paragraph were adapted from Pete Bsumek (2008), “Time to get down to it (should have been done long ago).” In Narrative, Rhetorical Genres, and Environmental Conflict: Responses to Schwarze’s Environmental Melodrama.” *Environmental Communication: A journal of nature and culture*, 2, 79-84.

anyone who has studied debate. It is tempting to simply dismiss such characterizations of debate as uniformed and irrelevant. Unfortunately, VNRLI's representation of debate as an unproductive and counter-productive communication process is not an isolated example. The home page of the National Coalition on Dialogue and Deliberation also posits debate as an unproductive means for engaging important issues of public concern: "Dialogue is a process that allows people, usually in small groups, to share their perspectives and experiences with one another about difficult issues we tend to just debate about or avoid entirely" (NCDD 2009a, NP). Furthermore, this discourse is circulating and becoming institutionalized. For example, the Center for Faculty Innovation at our university is offering a new workshop entitled "From debate to dialogue: Engaging millennial students in controversial topics." The workshop is based on the assumption that, "Millennial students have a proclivity to dialog over debate to avoid confrontations" and thus it "will model and examine a range of strategies that achieve productive discussions, engage students in civil controversy, and lead to an appreciation of opposing viewpoints" (Center for Faculty Innovation, James Madison University, NP). At a recent faculty meeting where this workshop was pitched, faculty was told they would learn how to encourage civil discussion instead of debate.

As Mitchell (2010) recently points out, the circulation of this tropic frame is not haphazard. Indeed, well-funded and respected organizations such as the Kettering Foundation and the National Coalition on Dialogue and Deliberation have picked-up this tropic frame and are running with it. These organizations are actively disseminating it as part of a major "research program that foregrounds the democratic telos of deliberative processes" (Mitchell 2010 p. 103). "Distrust of the debate process," Mitchell notes, "is almost paradigmatic amongst the theorists and practitioners of Kettering-style deliberative democracy" (p. 103). Needless to say, the continued circulation of the

Kettering Foundation's agenda for deliberative democracy does not bode well for debate as a public process, or for intercollegiate debate programs.

Tropic Frames: It is important to note that Both Flick (1998) and Tannen (1998) argue that our cultural malady, Debate, is the result of over-indulgence. Indeed, both Tannen and Flick are quick to point out that they are not suggesting that debate (understood in its best light as a process of inquiry or deliberation) is without merit. Flick is very careful about qualifying her diagnosis: "Conventional discussion, per se, is not the issue. The extent to which we unquestioningly accept its value and our habitual use of it is" (p. 4). In like fashion, Tannen claims "Conflict and opposition are as necessary as cooperation and agreement, but the scale is off balance, with conflict and opposition over-weighted" (p. 4). Tannen also qualifies her critique of debate by questioning the extent to which it is deployed: "My goal is not a make-nice false veneer of agreement or a dangerous ignoring of true opposition. I'm questioning the automatic use of adversarial formats—the assumption that it's always best to address problems and issues by fighting over them. I'm hoping for a broader repertoire of ways to talk to each other and address issues vital to us" (p. 26).

In the end, both Tannen (1998) and Flick (1998) make an important point about the over-indulgence of debate in our culture. Nonetheless, in spite of this qualification, there are clearly moments when, as Graff (2003) notes about Tannen, their argument "seems to adopt an abolitionist view of debate and oppositionality" (p. 86). To a large extent this argumentative slippage results from the effect of tropes. Flick and Tannen offer an informative and noteworthy critique of the tropic understanding of debate and argument in terms of war and battle metaphors. Their critique elucidates the tropic effects associated with the way many see, understand and experience debate and argument—as unproductive conflict. However, in the processes of presenting this criticism, "of naming the invisible," and pointing out the

“calcified nature of language” they also engender a new tropic theme: debate as disease. This in turn, produces rhetorical action.

Debate as foil: The rhetorical function of debate in the discourses of the D & D Community

The trope “debate as disease/dis-ease” casts debate in the role of argumentative foil. As a foil, the conception of debate as a disease enables a trope of “movement” in the discourse of the D & D community, which often calls for a “movement from debate to dialogue” (Flick 1998; Tannen 1998). In other words, debate becomes the argumentative foil, against which the D & D Community position their advocacy for alternative facilitated processes of dialogue and deliberation.

We can begin to reclaim debate from the discourse of disease and dis-ease by demonstrating some the ways that the concept of debate is uncharitably framed in the discourse of the D & D community. I am not arguing that the D & D community is purposely misrepresenting debate. Rather, I believe that many within that community are simply unfamiliar with the theories and practices associated with debate. This, of course, is not uncommon.

One of the most common ways that debate is defined and described in the discourse of the D & D community is in the form of a table or chart. These tables are designed to “[compare] dialogue, deliberation and debate in simple terms” (NCDD 2007b). This is done by contrasting aspects of the three processes, such as, the purpose and goals of the process, the attitudes and roles taken up by participants in the process, and the applicability of each process to different circumstances (Flick 1998, p. 36-37; Schirch & Campt 2007, p. 9). The following table taken from the scholarly work of Bone, Crockett, & Hodge (2006) offers one of the most charitable readings of debate within the D & D literature (p. 7-8).²

² This table is displayed on the “resources page” of the NCDD (National Coalition for Dialogue and Deliberation) website. It was also repeatedly

Debate	Dialogue	Deliberation
Compete	Exchange	Weigh
Argue	Discuss	Choose
Promote opinion	Build relationships	Make choices
Seek majority	Understand	Seek overlap
Persuade	Seek understanding	Seek common ground
Dig in	Reach across	Framed to make choice
Tight structure	Loose structure	Flexible structure
Express	Listen	Learn
Usually fast	Usually slow	Usually slow
Clarifies	Clarifies	Clarifies
Win/lose	No decision	Common ground
Most useful when: A position or course of action is being advocated and winning is the goal	When: People want to talk together about something without desiring any particular outcome from the conversation	Most useful when: A decision or criteria for a decision, about the best way(s) to approach an issue or problem is needed.

Tables like this serve four rhetorical functions. First, these tables often define debate by conflating debate with interpersonal conflict and/or “dirty politics” (Jamieson 1992). Second, they function as a visual “trope of movement,” which encourages readers to “move” away from debate to dialogue & deliberation. Third, debate, as an idea and a practice, serves as a scapegoat for the ills of democracy. Fourth, they offer definitions of debate that are much too narrow in scope. This in-turn reduces debate to a “contest of wills” in which, persuasion, self-interest and competition are valued at the expense of reason, understanding and cooperation.

referred to during an NCDD list-serve exchange on the value of debate in 2004.

First, advocates of D & D processes conflate scholarly definitions of argumentation and debate, in which debate is understood as a method of inquiry (Ehninger & Brockriede 1963, Ehninger 1966, 1970), or a principled communicative process (Brockriede 1972), with colloquial definitions of argument and debate in which debate is understood as a cantankerous dispute, or “dirty politics.” In so doing the advocates of D & D processes compare and contrast idealized, facilitated, principled D & D processes and practices to “a nasty argument.” This conflation creates a picture of debate as a no-holds-barred match in which distortion, manipulation and a plethora of dirty tricks are all part of the game.

For example, when Schirch and Campt (2007) compare and contrast debate and dialogue in their table, they note that in a debate the experiences of others are critiqued “as distorted and invalid,” while in a dialogue “people accept the experiences of others as real and valid” (p. 9). Another example from the same table claims that in a debate “strong emotions like anger are often used to intimidate the other side,” while in a dialogue “strong emotions like anger and sadness are appropriate when they convey the intensity of an experience or belief” (Schirch and Campt 2007, p. 9). These comparisons make sense only to the extent that those engaged in dialogue are participating in a professionally facilitated process. Or to the extent that those engaged in dialogue are being guided by principles such as those associated with “conflict management.” Indeed, Schirch and Campt (2007) note: “Effective dialogue between people of diverse experiences and beliefs usually requires the guidance of a facilitator” (p. 8), and that “the role of the facilitator may be the most important element of a dialogue” (p. 58). Additionally, the above comparisons between debate and dialogue assume that those engaged in debate are doing so without principle, or facilitated guidance. In contrast to this perspective, there is ample scholarly literature (Ehninger 1966, 1970; Brockriede 1972; Blythin 1979; Zarefsky 1994, 2001) as

well as practitioner literature (Broda-Bahm, Kempf and Driscoll 2004), which makes it clear that debate tactics associated with distortion and intimidation are antithetical to the principled practice of argumentation in general, and to the process of debate in particular.

Second, these tables serve as a visual trope of movement. This is important because even though the tables are meant to define communicative practices by comparing and contrasting them, the main function is to encourage readers to move away from debate toward dialogue and deliberation. There is both a literal performative and a figurative aspect to this trope. The literal performative aspect of the trope functions via the process of reading. By positioning debate on the left side of the table viewers literally move from debate to dialogue and deliberation as they read. The act of reading replicates the argument that is explicitly articulated in the subtitles of both Flick and Tannen's books "moving from debate to dialogue."³ In addition by conflating the definition of debate with unproductive conflict and defining it in terms of "dishonesty," "distortion," and "intimidation" these charts facilitate and encourage movement from debate to dialogue and deliberation by positioning debate as the cause of democratic dis-ease. In short, these charts generate rhetorical action through the use of "argument by definition" in which the "key definitional move is simply stipulated. As if it were a natural step along the way to justifying some other claim" (Zarefesky 1997, p. 5); thereby encouraging readers to literally move away from debate via the process of reading.

In this way debate becomes the foil against which alternative ways of engaging public life (dialogue and collaborative deliberative processes) are positioned, and thus, people who are leery of participating in a public

³ The subtitle to the second edition of Tannen's *The argument culture* was change to "Stopping America's war of words", suggesting that Tannen and her editors were trying to distance themselves from the "anti-debate" position.

forum are offered something different from the status quo, and reassured that they will be respected, protected and heard. Unfortunately, in the process, all qualification and nuance, such as it may have existed in the works of Flick and Tannen, is expunged.

One clear advantage to representing debate as a foil to alternative forms of democratic organizing and public engagement is that it can provide people with a reason to participate. However, there are also, perhaps unintended consequences that follow in the wake of this line of argument. Indeed, casting debate in the role of foil, and having those who profess to be the keepers of democracy's open processes denigrate the process of debate as they encourage and facilitate democratic engagement does not bode well for the long-term health of democratic culture. One reason for this is that when debate is cast in the role of argumentative foil, it also takes on the role of scapegoat.

As debate and debate culture are blamed for the ills in democracy other significant factors, which contribute to the communication habits that lead to disillusion, disgust and cynicism are ignored. As just one example consider Tannen's (1998) analysis of journalism. Tannen contends, as have many others, that "widespread mistrust, contempt and even hatred that many citizens now feel against the press is as dangerous—if less widely reported than—the mistrust, contempt and even hatred that many citizens feel against the government" (p. 53). She attributes these attitudes toward the press to its "habitual preference for stories about fights" (p. 33), "its tendency to think in polarized opposites" (p. 91), and its "attack dog" mentality (p. 91). She is not alone in levying these criticisms against the press. Nor is she alone in suggesting that we would be better served by a press that behaved as a "watch dog" instead of an "attack dog" (p. 91). Yet, when it comes to articulating the cause of these conventions she asserts: "I prefer to believe that the troubling effects I've described are the unintended result of the argument culture" (p. 53).

One troubling aspect of this diagnosis is that it puts the blame for press conventions upon “the argument culture” and in turn, upon the process of debate. The focus upon the argument culture diverts attention from other possible causes, including those associated with press and media practices, and the ways that individuals and organizations adapt their political strategies, tactics and messages to media conventions. Bennett (2009) and Deluca and Peebles (2000), for example, suggest that press conventions such as “the attack dog mentality”, and the tendency to frame stories in terms of fights, can, to a large extent, be attributed to the political economy of news media, and the visual orientation of contemporary media. Their critiques also suggest that the problems associated with journalism run much deeper than story frames.

Fourth, even in cases where advocates of D & D processes treat debate as a legitimate forum for public engagement (Bone, Crockett, & Hodge 2006) they utilize an operational definition of debate that is much too narrow in scope. These narrow definitions of debate unwittingly represent and construe the concept of debate exclusively in terms of clash and competition and by extension limit the purpose and utility of debate. D & D definitions and interpretations of debate and the act of debating are not incorrect. Debate is indeed characterized by persuasion (presenting the best possible case in support of or opposed to a particular proposition), self-interest (advocates who defend their case without hesitation) and competition (the clash of arguments, reasons and values). However, these are not the only characteristics of a debate—especially a well-organized debate.

When defining debate, D & D advocates focus their attention upon the stage where debaters advocate, “make their case” and clash with each other’s ideas. In doing so, D & D champions fail to notice that the advocates in a debate have a specific role to play, and that this role is but one of many roles associated with a principled facilitated communicative process. Other roles

include: the moderator who acts as a referee; the conveners who organize and promote the debate, set and negotiate ground rules, determine the purpose of the debate, and craft a proposition that will focus discussion on the desired topic and issues; and most importantly, the audience members who play a crucial role as participant critics and/or deliberators (Broda-Bahm, Kempf and Driscoll 2004).

By reducing a debate to acts of persuasion and clash in which debaters “compete,” “argue,” “promote opinions” and “dig-in,” D & D critics of debate fail to see that debaters are involved in a significantly different communicative process than “political spin doctors,” media campaign consultants or advertisers. Most importantly, they fail to see that debate is fundamentally a cooperative and collaborative enterprise.

Debate as Principled Process: A Call for an Activist Scholarly Agenda

One of the great ironies of the debate as disease/dis-ease trope is that it partakes in the very form of argumentation/conversational discussion that it seeks to cure with dialogue, understanding and facilitated deliberative processes. Antidotes, after-all, often involve the introduction of antibodies, which help a body “fight-off” disease or poisoning. Tropes that invoke a bio-medical model of treatment, a model infused with agonistic metaphors (fighting disease, cancer survivors, etc.), are themselves “infected” with metaphors grown in the lab of the argument culture (Sontag 1978). Even more to the point these agonistic metaphors label, stereotype and characterize debate in unproductive ways. It seems as though “the Debate Culture” is, indeed, the air we breathe. In other words, the framing of debate in terms of disease/dis-ease is inconsistent with the assumptions and principles that inform and guide the D & D community’s commitment to constructive public engagement processes.

Nonetheless, understanding processes, like debate, are important democratic tools. The more

process advocates are aware of the limits and capabilities of both sets of tools, the better their process advocacy. Similarly, the more we in the debate community understand the limits and the capabilities of the process of debating, the better we will be at helping others do the same. At the same time our advocacy of debate should be tempered by the knowledge that debate is but one of many communicative practices that are essential to democratic self-governance.

Engaging the D & D Community: There are three reasons why we in the debate community should cultivate a collegial and productive relationship with the D & D community. First, it will enable us to discourage the use of debate as a foil. Second, it will put us in a better position to encourage organizations like the Kettering Foundation to incorporate debate into their understanding of deliberative processes. This in turn will help raise the profile of debate as a democratic process and a scholarly field of study. Third, it will provide us with access to the foundation resources that fund the D & D community.

Before I sketch a view of debate as a principled facilitated process, one that I believe will enable a productive relationship with the D & D community, and call for a renewed scholarly research agenda; it is worth noting that there is much to praise in the D & D literature. In fact, it is fair to say that the D & D community and the debate community have much in common, including: a belief that transparent decision-making is superior to non-transparent decision-making, a rejection of coercive decision-making, and a profound faith that principled, civil, democratic interactions can and should lead to improved social knowledge, better communities, more humane organizations and improved decisions.⁴ One of

⁴ Members in both communities are also aware that when power is severely imbalanced, facilitated processes of dialogue, deliberation or debate are limited and can “potentially perpetuate discrimination in the

strengths of the D & D literature is the practical wisdom that its practitioners and social activists have produced. By translating research found in the fields of interpersonal communication, group communication, conflict studies and restorative justice (to name only a few) this literature offers useful insights that can help a facilitator, an organization leader or an individual better manage day-to-day interactions. More importantly, the D & D community is leap years ahead of the debate community with regard to their knowledge of, practice with, and development of techniques, or “tools,” for facilitating processes designed to encourage public engagement. They are also much more skilled at organizing public and civic forums, more “plugged-in” to organizations and foundations that support (financially, institutionally, etc.) such organizing, and more adept at identifying and tailoring appropriate “process tools” (forums, formats, etc.) to particular circumstances. Unfortunately, too many of the practitioners who organize and facilitate these processes, such as the Virginia Natural Resources Leadership Institute, use debate as a foil to encourage participation in these forums, and thus, their work denigrates the utility of debate as a democratic practice and virtue. In doing so, they are also turning their back on a potentially valuable process tool.

It is tempting to assume that the D & D community objects to debate merely because it is competitive and adversarial. However, their critique and distrust of debate runs much deeper than an objection to competition and a desire for “everyone to just get along.” Without a doubt, there are some within the D & D movement who place too much value on warm-fuzzy ideals. However, the vast majority of scholars and practitioners in the D & D community are much more sophisticated. These thinkers value dialogue and deliberation processes not as techniques for generating

name of peace” (Lozano-Reich and Cloud 2009). See for example, Schirch & Campt 2007; Warner and Bruschke 2001.

consensus, but as techniques for building community, managing conflict and for “fostering innovative solutions to problems and launching action” (NCDD 2009a, NP).

Sophisticated D & D community critiques of debate tend to associate debate with the “decide-announce-defend” or “top-down” decision making processes often utilized by public officials.⁵ Bone, Crockett & Hodge (2006) note, “public meetings tend to leave people discouraged” because meetings are “dominated by polarized groups” in which “adversarial encounters shut out lesser-heard, yet equally impacted people” (p. 4). In addition they contend “even when public participation is encouraged, it is likely that the community does not lead the process, but rather, it is a top-down ‘expert-client’ approach where knowledge is diffused to communities by experts” (Bone, Crockett, & Hodge 2006. p. 4). This format, critics of debate contend, creates “us against them scenarios,” that destroy community relationships, breed and solidify unproductive conflict and paralyze decision-making. Dialogue and deliberation processes are seen as an antidote to this situation, not because they create consensus, but because they “build on the capacities of the public to think, talk and act together in their common interests” and because they are “designed to produce a change in the way people habitually interact with each other over public issues” (Bone, Crockett & Hodge 2006, p. 5).

It is also tempting to assume that if D & D advocates better understood debate they would embrace it. However, I do not believe that this is the case. D & D critiques of debate challenge us to reconsider the purpose of debate. For quite some time scholars of debate have taken it as axiomatic that arguments occur because people disagree (Willard 1989; Bruschke 2004) and that debate provides a superior deliberative method

⁵ For an excellent analyses of the problems associated with the “decide-announce-defend” approach to public involvement in decision making and public hearings see Daniels and Walker 2001; Hajer 1995; Senecah 2001.

for identifying, evaluating, and testing pragmatic truth claims (Bruschke 2004; Zarefesky 2001) and for choosing among competitive fact, value and policy claims under conditions of uncertainty (Ehninger 1966, 1970; Zarefesky 1994, 2001). In contrast, D & D advocates focus upon the social legitimacy of the truth claims produced, the cultural (communication) habits that are cultivated, and the civic identities that are experienced as people participate in forums and deliberative processes. In others words, D & D critiques challenge us to consider what kind of democratic citizen/denizen participates in a debate, what kind of communication habits are cultivated when communities debate and what kind of community is built when people engage in public debate.

Debate as Principled Facilitated Process: While it is beyond the scope of this paper to address and thoroughly theorize a relationship between public debate processes and community building, I believe that it is crucial for our scholarly community to take this issue seriously.⁶ In the remainder of this paper I offer one possible entrée into this conversation. I propose that we think of debate as a Principled Facilitated Process. This is a view of debate that should be persuasive to the D & D community. What follows, then, is a brief sketch of some key principles that I believe enable us view debate as a principled facilitated process. By providing this sketch, I also attempt to point out some potentially problematic and limiting tropes within our own scholarly tradition. This sketch is offered as a way to start a conversation and as theoretical food for thought in an attempt to reenergize scholarship on debate.

Debate, as a principled facilitated process is tailor-made for engaging the D & D community in both name and substance. This does not mean that I am

⁶ Here I am not concerned with what is often referred to as “the debate community” at inter-collegiate debate tournaments. Instead I am concerned with the process of public debate and the promotion of debate as a legitimate and essential mode of democratic communication.

proposing a radically new version of debate. Nor am I suggesting that the concept of debate merely needs a better PR slogan. Rather, I am positing a conception of debate that emphasizes certain aspects of the debate and argumentation canon, and deemphasizes other aspects of our canon.

Debate as a Principled Facilitated Process is defined by four key concepts. First and foremost debate is a cooperative and collaborative communication process. This does not mean that I am proposing a non-competitive conception of debate. It also does not mean that I am calling for the reconception of debate as a species of the genius “cooperative argumentation” as described by Makau and Marty (2001). Rather I am proposing that we throw out the traditional distinction between “adversarial” and “non-adversarial” argumentation. I propose that debate be understood in a broader context as the cooperative and collaborative production of social knowledge. Debate, Zarefesky (2001) explains, is “fundamentally cooperative rather than competitive” because it is “primarily a method for collective decision making” (p. 193-194). When Zarefesky refers to debate as a “seemingly adversarial format” he points us in the right direction (2001, p. 193). We need to find ways to talk about debate in terms of cooperation and collaboration instead of framing it in adversarial and competitive terms. This is crucial at this historical juncture because it provides us with an opportunity to reorient public audiences to debate in an era “where many citizens use dueling monologues such as presidential debates, or Crossfire-style television programs as benchmark referents informing their notions of what debate entails” (Mitchell, et al 2010).

Second, method is more important than outcome. The purpose of debate is the generation of social and public knowledge, not winning or losing. Too many people associate debate with winning and losing. However, a debate itself is not a decision making process (Ehninger 1966, p. 182). A debate is a means for presenting and rigorously subjecting ideas and beliefs “to

the searching tests of reason" (Ehninger 1958, p. 27). The process of debating offers a sound and useful tool for testing, refining and generating social knowledge (Zarefesky 2001, p. 194). Indeed, any number of dialogic and deliberative processes may be employed prior to or following a debate.

The idea that debate is a method is amply articulated in the scholarly canon of debate (Ehninger 1958, 1966, 1970; Brockreide 1972; Zarefesky 1979, 2001). Yet there is a significant limitation to this literature. The method of debate is generally framed as preferable to other forms of deliberation because it is more reliable and more humane (Ehninger 1966, p. 184). However, this defense of debate employs an argumentative "foil" of its own. Debate is usually compared to either chance, in which case it is determined to be more reliable, or authority and intuition, in which case it is deemed to be more humane (Ehninger 1966, 1970). However, these are not the only options for comparison. Thus, there is an urgent need for research that compares and contrasts the relative advantages and disadvantages of debate as a method of inquiry and critical deliberation to those associated with different dialogic and deliberative processes. Mitchell's (2010) recent scholarship on the use of switch-side debating by government agencies, in which he compares the motivations, purposes and forums related to their use of debate, is exemplary in this regard.

Third, debate requires facilitated argumentation and argument comparison. Debates produce social knowledge "through a process of successive comparisons or tests. By its nature, debate is two-sided: one either supports or opposes the resolution" (Zarefesky 2001, p. 194). This process is often referred to as "issue clash," or the comparison of mutually exclusive positions (Ehninger 1966). A debate then offers a formalized forum, which facilitates a particular kind of argumentative engagement in which the relative merits of mutually exclusive claims are compared. Not only does the method of debate ensure that ideas will be tested, it

also ensures that the test will be rigorous. On the one hand, faulty reasoning is checked because advocates are encouraged to present only ideas and evidence that can withstand such a methodological challenge. On the other hand, groupthink is checked because the comparison-based method ensures that the “devil’s advocate” will be heard (Bruschke 2004).

The facilitation of argument comparison, or clash, is perhaps one of the main sources of confusion about debate. Not only, do critics fail to recognize that the agonistic aspects of a debate are at root collaborative, they also fail to see that they are essential to the method of inquiry. This is why we should supplant tropic frames of clash with frames of comparison. Likewise we should discourage tropic orientations of winning and losing, while we encourage tropes associated with the generation of knowledge and education.

Fourth, debate is guided by the principle of bilateralism. For debate to function as a legitimate method of inquiry and/or an aid to deliberation, participants (debaters, audience members, conveners, organizers and moderators) must adhere to the principle of bilateralism (Ehinger 1970, Brockreide 1972). This means that those involved in a debate forsake coercion as a means of persuasion, and instead “enter into an agreement of a special sort” (Ehninger 1970, p. 102-103). This agreement entails the cultivation of “bilateral relationships,” which are characterized by “power parity” and the acknowledgement and affirmation by all concerned of the “personhood” of other participants (Brockreide 1972, p. 5). It also means that all of the participants in a debate (convener, advocate, audience member, etc.) are aware of the responsibilities associated with their role, and that they agree to fulfill these responsibilities in accordance to the principle of bilateralism (Broda-Bahm, Kempf and Driscoll 2004). Ehninger (1966) and Zarefesky (2001) suggest that this means that debaters assume a position of “restrained partisanship.” The extent to which the characterization of bilateralism and restrained partisanship adequately

capture the full breadth of ethical responsibilities associated with all aspects of a debate is a worthy topic for future research.

Finally, we need to find “quick and simple” ways to facilitate public understanding of debate. I believe that a simple and effective way to do this is to draw comparisons between “good” productive debate and “bad” counterproductive non-debate. At the 2008 National Coalition on Dialogue and Deliberation convention a colleague and I attempted to do just that. In our presentation and discussions we compared and contrasted debate as Principled Facilitated Process to “Crossfire-style debate.” In short we used “Crossfire” as a trope for unprincipled debate in order to reframe our audiences’ perceptions of debate. Our argument was very well received, and if our experience is at all representative, I believe that this approach to promoting better public understanding of debate has a lot of potential. I am not so bold as to suggest that I have all the answers, but I am confident that this approach is a very good fit for our current rhetorical situation.⁷

Conclusion

For those of us familiar with radically different understandings of debate than those expressed by the D & D community—debate as critical deliberation (Ehninger 1958), debate as method (Enhinger 1966), debaters and arguers as lovers of wisdom and truth (Brockriede 1972), debate as hypothesis testing (Zarefsky 1979), debate as critical thinking and ethical inquiry (Muir 1993), debate as deliberative process (Zarefsky 2001)—the construction of debate as disease may seem absurd. However, it would be unwise on our part to simply dismiss the D & D community as mistaken or irrelevant. Indeed, we have much to learn from, and much to gain by thoughtfully and productively engaging the D & D community. As a community of scholars and

⁷ A short video of our discussion with NCDD participants is available at: http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Mc_Mg2hwAdU

teachers we, in the intercollegiate debate community, have kept, advanced and advocated for the principles, practices and values associated with debate on more than one occasion. Today we have much to gain by rising to the challenge yet again.

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